The algorithm starts at the root, that corresponds to the empty string (because the path that leads to it is, as well, empty). At each step, we have to compare the target word `s` (“`amt`”, in the example) to the word corresponding to current node; in particular, we compute the distance between each prefix of s and the word associated to current node.

So, for the root, the distance between the empty string and… the empty prefix of “`amt`” (which also is the empty string, obviously) is `0` (because they match); the distance between “” and “`a`” is `1`, because we need to add one character to the former to make the latter, and so on…